



Ms. Lae Lae Htun (PhD Student, Saitama University, Japan)

Biography: Hi, I'm Lae Lae Htun. Currently pursuing a Ph.D. in computer science at Saitama University, Japan, my research explores the intersection of speech communication, phonetics, and second language acquisition. Outside of my research, I contribute to the community by organizing the campus Google Developer Student Club and working with the LIGHT Japanese Language School in Myanmar.

Analysis of the "Fluent but Cold" Phenomenon: Usage and Prosody of Non-Lexical Backchannels among Myanmar Learners of Japanese

Abstract: In Japanese conversation, listeners act as "co-speakers" who build conversational harmony through aizuchi (backchanneling). However, Myanmar learners often give a cold impression to native speakers despite having sufficient language proficiency, which this study aims to clarify by examining the "usage and prosody" of non-lexical aizuchi. By analyzing 180 minutes of free conversation between native speakers and learners, alongside preliminary perceptual experiments, the study identified a reversal in frequency (native speakers predominantly use "n," while learners use "a") and a "fixation of prosody" where learners rely on short, flat tones rather than empathetic, flexible pitches. These findings suggest that learners' aizuchi lacks the pragmatic function of empathy, demonstrating that the "fluent but cold" impression is linked to this prosodic bias and highlighting the need for better prosody instruction in Japanese language education.



Date: 8 Mar 2026 (SUN),



Time: 10:00 to 11:30 (ICT, UTC+7)

12:00 to 13:30 (JST, UTC+9)

Webex Meeting Link: 

